

MARY ANN WILSON LUNT, 1834-1910

Mary Ann Wilson Lunt, daughter of William and Martha Phillips Wilson, was born in Carlisle, Cumberland, England, January 19, 1834. At the age of three her mother died and she and her father went to live with his mother. At the age of four her grandmother Wilson put her in kindergarten where she was taught to sew, knit and read.

At the age of six she could read the Bible. She attended the Church of England regularly with her grandmother who required her to listen so attentively that when she was unable to go Mary Ann could give her a complete account of the service.

When she was twelve years old Lord Wharton presented her with a Bible for repeating from memory the catechism, the prayers, the 1st, 15th, 25th, 37th, 101st, 113th and 145th Psalms.

Another cultural advantage was voice training and she was chosen as soloist in the Church of England Choir in Carlisle. On several occasions she was asked to sing for Queen Victoria.

At 17 years of age she received a diploma as a trained governess. All the time she was in finishing school, special emphasis was given to governess training. The health part of this training came in very handy after she reached Cedar City and all during her life as she had eight children, and many, many times she was doctor and nurse in maternity cases.

In 1856 when she was 22 years old some friends invited her to go with them to a conference held by the L.D.S. Church. They mentioned especially a tall, handsome missionary that would be there from America. She went with them more out of curiosity than for any other reason. To her surprise, this handsome American was dressed and acted like an English gentleman and everything he said made her more anxious to become better acquainted. She accepted the teachings of the L.D.S. missionaries and on July 27, 1856 was baptized by Thomas Adams. Upon hearing of this her father disowned her and the minister in the Church of England, where she had been active as soloist, preached her funeral sermon saying, "another sheep has been lost from the fold."

That same year her grandmother Wilson died. Her father remarried and Mary Ann went to live at the mission headquarters. There her skill with a needle was made use of by helping to keep missionaries clothes in repair and getting

clothes made for the saints who were getting ready to come to Utah.

Upon the advice of Henry Lunt, Mary Ann Wilson sold her household effects, paid all her obligations, packed all personal belongings and went to Liverpool to make arrangements for her emigration to the U.S.A.

While staying at the Mission Headquarters someone put five dollars among their papers on the table which was one of Mary Ann Wilsons duties to straighten. When she found the money, she took it to the Landlady who said it had been put there as a test of her honesty.

On March 25, 1857 the ship "George Washington" sailed from Liverpool bound for Boston. She was one of 817 saints on the ship. They were on the sea six weeks; Mary Ann was so sick she said she wished the ship would sink. When within sight of land a stubborn wind too strong for a sail ship pushed them back. They were five days more before the ship docked in Boston.

The trip across the plains was in the Jesse B. Martins Company. Three days out a stampede occurred among the oxen. Wagons were broken and many animals killed, also a child and an old man. Such a catastrophe to happen when everything they had started with seemed so indispensable.

The order was given that only absolute necessities could be taken; so stoves, relics, feather beds, books and furniture of all kinds were left on the plains. Their backs were turned on them and the journey proceeded. One little bundle Mary Ann tucked away with the necessary articles held some of her handwork, new songs just out in England: "Ben Bolt", "Annie Laurie," "Shells of the Ocean" and others.

All able bodied people were required to walk. With the exception of a few miles Mary Ann walked the full distance to Salt Lake, arriving with moccasins bought from the Indians after her shoes were gone.

On October 7, 1857 President Brigham Young performed the marriage of Mary Ann Wilson to Henry Lunt in the presence of Henry's first wife, Ellen Whittaker Lunt, and Ellen's father. Four days later they left for Cedar City by ox teams.

Their first home was a wagon box, which contained one chair and very few dishes, mostly tin.

Cedar City had three locations. It was originally located near a knoll north of the present day cemetery. The town was moved south and west about a mile and a fort was constructed. When that site was found to be in danger of flooding, the town was moved again, this time to the upper side of the creek, closer to the canyon.

Henry Lunt purchased a lot and commenced building a new home. When the house was finished it had 15 rooms, an attic, a cellar and three large porches. Both wives lived in it. It also served as a hotel where Brigham Young and all travelers stayed during the Silver Reef Boom.

Truly the broad minds and unselfish characters of the two women, Ellen and Mary Ann, were put to the test and not found wanting. These two women, wives of one man, complemented each other.

Ellen's soul was big. She was a well trained, happy, witty woman. She knew the practical ways of life. She was a good cook and house manager; she could weave, sew and knew how to make good practical clothes. She had no children.

Mary Ann had eight children, three sons and five daughters. She was pretty, with light auburn hair. She made good use of her training in fine arts.

Mary Ann taught school, walking a mile from the Old Fort to the New Town. She became known as Southern Utah's nightingale. She was a member of the choir and taught music, and was also a member of the dramatic society.

Neighbors say she sang while she worked in the field helping her husband or while helping with the housework. Everyone could knit, but her fingers simply flew. She could knit one pair of men's socks in a day. Ellen taught her to spin.

Guests at the Lunt Hotel long remembered the unusual treatment they received there. Two charming women, both gracious and such good entertainers. All eight children could sing, do their own accompaniment and entertain at joke telling.

One of the family's oldest customs was singing hymns before breakfast. All eight children spoke of Ellen and Mary Ann with the same love and affection.

From 1875 to 1879 Mary Ann was chosen counselor to the president of the Relief Society. Upon resignation of Ellen, who

accompanied her husband to Mexico, Mary Ann was made Stake Relief Society President, and for 25 years she was devoted to the interest of the Relief Society work.

Mary Ann stayed in Cedar City with her children who were all married and had families. After the death of her husband in Mexico her health gradually failed and she passed away April 7, 1910 at Cedar City at the age of 76 years.

According to Henry H. Lunt, a grandson of Henry, the Lunt Hotel and Stage Stop was located on First East and 100 North in Cedar City. It was constructed of native adobe brick and was a large; two-story building with white trim. There was a big living room containing a fireplace, with eight rooms on the ground floor and eight upstairs (In addition, later there were more rooms built in the back). The house had a large porch. When the stage coaches pulled in, the travelers were unloaded near the porch, and the drivers took the I coaches on the cobblestone driveway to the back of the building where there was a large barn and accommodations for thirty horses.

The Lunts had several adjoining lots on which they grew a large garden and a fruit orchard containing apples, peaches, plums and apricots. The home had an underground storage unit where meat, butter and milk was kept. There was also a cellar for the storage of fruits and vegetables. The family lived in the east section of the home.

A belfry was on top of the building and the rope which was used to ring the bell hung through the house into the hallway. They rang the bell to call people to church, for funerals, and for other occasions.

All transportation was on unimproved roads and the travelers going through town put their horses in the hotel barn. The Stage Stop advertised with a sign on mainstreet saying that there was a "house of entertainment one block East. Good accommodations for travelers, reasonable rates, hay, grain and stabling, and there was a telegraph office located in the hotel." All the Lunt children inherited good singing voices from their parents and, undoubtedly, were part of the entertainment.

It was said that Mary Ann did most of the cooking, with the help of two dependable workers, Mary Walker and Emmeline Pendleton.

(What follows is taken from the Henry Lunt Biography by Evelyn K. Jones - pages 437-439.)

With the help of her children, Henry Lunt's second wife, Mary Ann Wilson Lunt, who stayed in Cedar City when Henry and the other three wives moved to Mexico, continued to run the Lunt Hotel until she died April 6, 1910. Her biography, along with her obituary, were published in the Iron County Record On April 15, 1910. The following is part of the article which was written by a friend, J. P. Mackelprang.

Sister Mary Ann Wilson Lunt, whose death occurred on the 6th of this month, was born January 19, 1834 in Carlisle, Cumberland, England. She married Henry Lunt soon after her arrival in Salt Lake City the fall of 1857. She became the mother of eight children, three sons and five daughters, all of whom survive her with the exception of her daughter, Florence, whose death last December 14 cast a gloom of sorrow which Sister Lunt seemed unable to overcome. Her sons and daughters are all honored residents and good members of the faith of their parents in this community. She was the grandmother of 61 grandchildren, fifty-one now living, and great grandmother of eight children, seven now living. Her first deep sorrow was in the death of her husband several years ago in Mexico, but she was surrounded by a devoted family and her life has been full of good works, not only in the home but in other capacities.

From the year 1875 to 1879 Sister Lunt was a counselor to the president of our Relief Society. In 1879 the first Stake organization was effected by Bishop W. H. Dame of Parowan. [Mary Ann was Counselor to Ellen, in that organization for twelve years and, when Ellen went to Mexico, Mary Ann took her place] For nine years the position of President of the Stake Relief Society was held and the duties faithfully performed by her. In the year 1900 she was honorably released by the presiding authorities. Thus, during 25 years, her time was more or less devoted to the establishment and improvement of the Relief Societies in the different parts of the Stake. Her counsel and advice were always words of wisdom, at all times encouraging mothers to instill into the hearts of their children love for the principles of truth and virtue and obedience to their parents. For some time past her presence in our meetings had been limited on account of her health, but when she was able to attend she was welcomed

for we all loved to hear her talk. Her heart and soul were in the advancement of the work of God. Her example was one we all might do well to follow, both in the home and abroad.

Maude and her husband, Daniel Matheson, and their six children had lived with Maude's mother, Mary Ann, for some time before her death in 1910. Two of the children were eleven-year-old twin daughters, and their youngest child was two years old. More than twenty years later in 1932, Ianthe, one of the twins, wrote the following about her grandmother Mary Ann Lunt:

Although she died when I was but eleven years old, her sweet and noble influence has permeated my life. Any child should be considered fortunate, indeed, who has had the privilege of close association with a grandmother of such sweet character. There were five of us in the family and she cared for each of us in turn. Her room had a private entrance and whichever one of us happened to be sick with measles, whooping cough, or what happened to be going the rounds at the time, would be taken into her room away from the others. She would isolate herself with the sick one and make the period of isolation a very pleasant experience indeed, with songs, stories and games of which she seemed to have an unlimited supply.

She was an extensive reader and was delighted to read of current events. In reading about the 'horseless carriage' I remember she said, 'Wouldn't that be fine for the, Relief Society sisters to have, then we wouldn't have to depend on one of the men to hitch up the team.' I well remember her delight over the electric lights and her keen interest in the first motion pictures. As her eyesight failed, Violet, my twin sister, and I took turns reading to her. When we came to a word we had to spell out to her, it was a puzzle to us how she could tell us what it was before we had finished spelling it. In her home she was queenly, gentle and beloved by her children who were happy to give her every attention in her declining years.